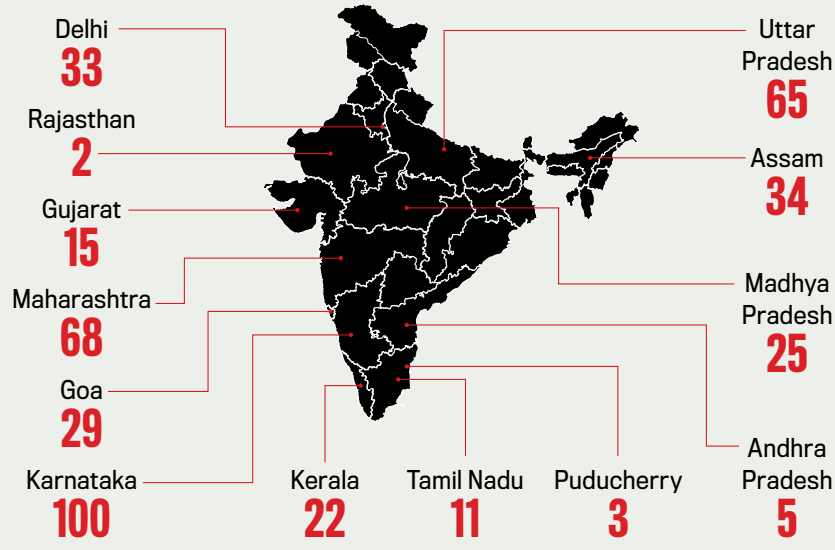
THE BIG BUST

More than 400 PFI activists were arrested or detained in two rounds of operation—on September 22 and 27—across 13 states

Note: This doesn't include the 1,809 PFI activists arrested or detained by the Kerala Police in the past week, in cases not related to the nationwide swoop led by the NIA



the NDF eventually merged with two other Muslim organisations from neighbouring states—Karnataka Forum for Dignity and the Manitha Neethi Pasarai in Tamil Nadu—to emerge as the PFI on February 16, 2006.

Investigating agencies allege that PFI members are aligned in ideology to the Muslim Brotherhood (MB), a transnational Sunni Islamist organisation, that took root in Egypt in 1928. PFI cadres protested outside the Egyptian embassy in New Delhi in 2015, against the death sentence given to former Egypt president Mohammed Morsi, who was affiliated to the MB. The Brotherhood, whose aim was to establish an Islamic state ruled by Sharia law, is well known for its slogan: 'Islam is the solution.' Prior to Partition, it was seen as a socioreligious organisation and, impressed by MB's aims, Abdul al-Maududi, the founder of the Jamaat-e-Islami, popularised it in the subcontinent. After Independence, with Maududi migrating to Pakistan, the Jamaat-e-Islami Hind embraced India's Constitution and remained moderate in approach. But a youth wing, the Students' Islamic Movement of India (SIMI) formed in Aligarh in April 1977, turned radical.

SIMI's mission was to "liberate India" from western materialistic influence and get Muslim society to live according to an Islamic code. Some of its oft-repeated objectives were restoration of the 'khilafat' (caliphate), emphasis on 'ummah' (Muslim brotherhood), and the need for *jihad* (spiritual war) to establish the supremacy of Islam. The Jamaat distanced itself from SIMI by floating the Students Islamic Organisation (SIO). Meanwhile, because of its alleged involvement in several terror cases in the country, a ban was imposed on SIMI in 2001, shortly after the 9/11 attacks. Investigating agencies saw the PFI as a far more sophisticated, rebranded version,

AROUND 1,400 CRIMINAL CASES HAVE BEEN REGISTERED AGAINST THE CADRES OF PFI AND ITS FRONT ORGANISATIONS IN DIFFERENT STATES

as many of its top leaders, including Salam, Rahiman, Koya and PFI national executive member Abubacker, were SIMI office-bearers at some point in the early 1980s. Rejecting such conclusions in an earlier interview, Koya had said, "SIMI said Islam was the only solution to India's problems, but we hold that India is a pluralistic country with many religions. We never conformed to SIMI's ideas."

ORGANISATIONAL MIGHT

Though confining its objectives within the constitutional realm, even including specifically non-Islamic terms such as yoga, ayurveda and Hindi and Sanskrit slogans in its discourse, PFI's objective, according to investigating agencies, was to establish an assertive Muslim organisation that would be both demographically and democratically powerful in India by 2047. The agencies allege that the outfit had quietly been building muscle in several cities and rural areas across the country, including training hit squads. In fact, the rapid